

Episode 1 — The Listener

Full Production Script · v1.2 — VO-LOCK CANDIDATE

v1.1 + third review pass: all 12 fix-before-recording items · 11 July 2026 · pending table read + runtime timing test

"Her last message to the show has no words in it. Forty seconds of someone else in her house."

FORMAT CANON & THE CLOCK

The tip line: "keeps voices, timestamps and nothing else. That's the promise." Anonymising by design. **Temporality:** case alerts during the investigation (L1, L5); full episode after (L12). **The absolute clock:** Dot's final message is timestamped **3:04 a.m., Friday**. The episode opens Monday (Day 1 — "three nights ago" is true exactly once, in L1). All later references use the weekday/timestamp, never relative time. Datelines: D1 Mon (L1–L3) · D2 Tue (L4–L5) · D3 Wed (L6–L8) · D4 Thu (L9–L10; both branch results land Day 4 — public by mid-afternoon, protected by evening) · D5 Fri (L11) · D6 Sat (L12).

LEAD STRUCTURE

#	ID	TYPE	TITLE	DAY	GATES	REQUIREMENT FRAMING (FAMILY)	BAND
1	e1_tip	Podcast · VO	The Tip Line	1	start → spawns 2, 3	set up the rig (forensic — guaranteed one-merge, no randomness)	Easy · 20
2	e1_forty	Evidence	The Forty Seconds	1	spawned by 1	take the audio apart (forensic)	Easy · 20
3	e1_archive	Data	Three Years of Goodnights	1–2	spawned by 1	tag and cross-file the archive (forensic)	Standard · 50
4	e1_bridge	Discuss (Gerald)	The Volume-Up	2	2 + 3	a round at the Anchor (harbour/bar)	Standard · 50
5	e1_pod1	Podcast · VO	Case Alert: Dot Ellis	2	4 → spawns 6, 7, 8	cut and publish the alert (forensic)	Milestone · 200 + 20 energy
6	e1_cottage	Evidence	The Cold Kettle	3	spawned by 5	document the scene properly (fingerprint)	Hard · 95 — with progress toasts
7	e1_inspector	Interview	The Man Who Came at Noon	3	spawned by 5	door-knocking supplies (diner food)	Standard · 50

8	e1_boats	Money Trail	The Quiet Boats	3	spawned by 5	chart three years of river traffic (harbour/bar)	Hard · 95 — with progress toasts
9	e1_delcruz	Interview · BRANCH	Off the Record	4	7 + 8	case packet for the bench (forensic)	Standard · 50
10	e1_trail	Data	Where Dot Went	4	6 + 9	assemble the paper trail (forensic)	Standard · 50
11	e1_hills	Location · CLIMAX	The Hill Cottage	5	10	the drive up (harbour/bar)	Very Hard · 185 + 2 ingots — with progress toasts
12	e1_close	Podcast · VO	Goodnight, Harbour	6	11	ceremonial: one low-tier item. Reward, not workload.	Milestone · 500 + 20 energy + 3 ingots

Portraits: Ally, Gerald, Dot, Del Cruz. Mo, Mrs. Vale, Vera quoted in narration. First merge goal opens after L1n3 (~45s); rig-merge is deterministic (pieces pre-placed). L6/L8/L11 emit per-requirement progress toasts (flavor strings specced in production notes). Flags: `aq.lead.e1_*.seen`; `e1.phase1.complete`; `e1.ep01.complete`; `aq.e1.truth_public/aq.e1.truth_protected` → *PUBLIC TRUTH* / *PROTECTED TRUTH* on case summary. Node counts generated from asset data.

PHASE 1

L1 · E1_TIP — "THE TIP LINE" (PODCAST, VO) · DAY 1, MONDAY

8–12s excerpt only; vague caption. First merge opens after n3 — one guaranteed merge, then n4–5.

	SPEAKER	EMOTION	LINE
1	Dot (voicemail)	happy	[warm, amused, unhurried] It's Dot from Rivermouth, love. Nothing worth troubling you with — the gulls held a parliament on my roof, and the quiet boats went by twice. Say goodnight to the harbour for me, Ally.
2	Tip line — 3:04 a.m., Friday	—	[An excerpt from her final message. Muffled movement inside a house. A strained metallic sound. An engine idling somewhere outside. It cuts off.]
3	Ally	neutral	[polished host voice, fatigue underneath] My show ends the same way every week: I read out the tip-line number and say, tell me what this city won't. The line keeps voices, timestamps and nothing else. That's the promise. Dot has left the last message after every episode for three years.
► FIRST MERGE GOAL — "Set up the rig." Deterministic single merge. Nodes 4–5 on completion.			
4	Ally	sad	[remorse under restraint] Three nights ago — 3:04 on Friday morning — she left the message you just heard part of. Forty seconds. No words. She opened the line and let the house speak for her. It waited three days in my queue. I was busy making a show about listening.
5	Ally	neutral	[resolve; host register] Dot, if you can hear this: goodnight, the harbour misses you. Everyone else — this is Echoes of Havenbay. The tip line is open. This week, it's mine to answer.

L2 · E1_FORTY — "THE FORTY SECONDS" (EVIDENCE) · DAY 1

Full recording as the object. Segment replay UI is a v1.x note — v1 presents discoveries as nodes. No relative dates.

	SPEAKER	EMOTION	LINE
1	Ally	neutral	I loaded the whole of Friday's message into the studio. Forty seconds, one sound at a time.
2	Ally	neutral	First: a floorboard, twice. The same squeak opens twelve of her older messages — the same three footsteps before she starts talking. Her hall, by the phone table. Whoever moved on Friday was standing where Dot stands to talk to me.
3	Ally	neutral	Then a strained spring — her back door, opened slow. The way you open a door you don't want heard. And outside, faint but steady: a diesel engine, idling. Waiting for somebody.
4	Ally	surprised	The steps are the tell. Eight of them, unhurried, and every second one lands harder. I can't tell you he limps. I can tell you the house does, when he walks through it.
5	Ally	neutral	Somebody was in Dot's house at three in the morning. She kept the line open and her mouth shut — braver in forty seconds than most of us manage in a year. Now let's find her street.

L3 · E1_ARCHIVE — "THREE YEARS OF GOODNIGHTS" (DATA) · DAY 1-2

	SPEAKER	EMOTION	LINE
1	Ally	neutral	Three years of messages, most under a minute. I used to pick one to close the show — Dot knew, and loved it. "Play the one about the gulls," she told me once. "I was very good in that one."
2	Ally	neutral	Tonight they're not a closing segment. They're a map. A school bell in the daytime messages — half past eight, then noon, term time only. And under the late calls, a low mechanical note every twenty-odd seconds.
3	Ally	worried	And the boats. Years of them, mentioned like weather. Then three weeks ago the message changed: "the pretty one came close tonight — two-note horn, no lights, and a funny mark on the funnel, like a fish-hook." I played that one on the show.
4	Ally	neutral	A school that rings at eight-thirty and noon. A machine that breathes every twenty seconds. Gerald has heard every machine this city ever built. Time to buy my grandfather a drink.

L4 · E1_BRIDGE — "THE VOLUME-UP" (DISCUSS — GERALD) · DAY 2, TUESDAY

	SPEAKER	EMOTION	LINE
1	Ally	neutral	The Anchor, Tuesday-quiet. Mo had the corner booth held before I asked. I handed Gerald the headphones and told him what was on them. He didn't flinch. He turned the volume up.
2	Gerald	neutral	Loop the low note for me, love. Just that. Nothing else in my ears.
3	Ally	neutral	I looped it. He counted under his breath, pencil ticking the table. Then he took the headphones off. Twenty-two seconds.
4	Gerald	worried	Swing-bridge counterweight — Rivermouth reach. The old crossing sings when boats run late. Your Dot lives close enough to hear the river breathe. So did the man in her hall. Mind how you go down there.
5	Ally	neutral	On the way out I played Mo three seconds of Dot's voice. She stopped polishing the glass. "Dorothy Ellis. Cleaned Chandler Road school thirty years. Tuesday quiz, table six — tell her it misses her." Rivermouth. Chandler Road. We're close.

L5 · E1_POD1 — "CASE ALERT: DOT ELLIS" (PODCAST, VO — MILESTONE) · DAY 2

Street name kept OFF the public alert — the show practices what this episode preaches. Fires e1.phase1.complete.			
	SPEAKER	EMOTION	LINE
1	Ally	neutral	<i>[host register; steadier than she feels]</i> This is Echoes of Havenbay, with a case alert. Her name is Dot Ellis, from Rivermouth. At 3:04 on Friday morning, someone was inside her house. She hasn't been heard from since.
2	Ally	neutral	Police logged a welfare check. No forced entry, no report from family, and an adult is allowed to leave home without explaining herself. They won't call it an abduction. I'm not asking them to — yet.
3	Ally	worried	So we do what this show does. We knock on Rivermouth's doors ourselves — and you'll notice I'm not saying her street on this feed. If you knew Dot Ellis, the tip line is open, and it keeps no names.
4	Ally	neutral	<i>[quiet steel; to one listener]</i> One more thing, for whoever needs to hear it. She left us your footsteps. Eight of them — eight steps too slow to stay invisible. That was Friday. We're faster now.

PHASE 2

L6 · E1_COTTAGE — "THE COLD KETTLE" (EVIDENCE) · DAY 3, WEDNESDAY

Scene untouched — no glass. Progress toasts: "Mail: three days deep" · "The kitchen: packed in the dark".

	SPEAKER	EMOTION	LINE
1	Ally	neutral	Eleven Chandler Road. A blue gate, a garden kept the way you keep a promise — and Dot's car in the drive, dry ground beneath it. It hasn't moved since before the rain.
2	Ally	neutral	Mrs. Vale next door has held the spare key for years — Dot's own arrangement: use it if the curtains stay shut two mornings running. This was the third. She went in first. I followed.
3	Ally	sad	Kettle cold. Bed made. Reading glasses gone, coat gone, the little case she took to church gone. She packed — quick, in the dark, but she packed. You don't pack for the river.
4	Ally	surprised	The hall table: her phone charger, empty. The phone was gone. I hoped that meant it went with her. And on the cradle, dead centre, where the phone should sleep — a coin. Old brass, worn smooth. Placed. Not dropped.
5	Ally	worried	I didn't touch it. I photographed where it lay, backed us both out of the hall, and kept the room untouched until Del arrived. Gerald's answer to the photo took a full minute: "Where was it." Then: "Don't put that on the show, love."
6	Ally	neutral	I've heard my grandfather discuss murders with his mouth full. I've never heard him go quiet. Back to work.

L7 · E1_INSPECTOR — "THE MAN WHO CAME AT NOON" (INTERVIEW) · DAY 3

The dead rear lamp planted here — pays off at L11 and grounds the protected-branch trace.

	SPEAKER	EMOTION	LINE
1	Ally	neutral	Rivermouth doors open for coffee and a box from the Corner Diner — they packed it heavy when they heard why. Mrs. Vale remembered him without prompting: a gas man, ten days back, lanyard doing the work. No company name she knew. Nobody had scheduled anything.
2	Ally	surprised	Her doorbell camera kept eleven seconds of him. Tall. Careful. Face angled off-lens like a man with practice. Every second step lands heavier — the house wasn't imagining. And at the edge of frame, a pale van waited at the kerb. Left rear lamp, dead.
3	Ally	worried	He went to Dot's door first. Twenty minutes inside, in daylight. My working theory: the first visit mapped what her window could see. The second came back for whatever she'd kept of it.
4	Ally	neutral	Whether he came to frighten her, or silence her, or worse — I don't get to know that yet, and neither do you. What I know: he plans, he returns, and he's on camera. Eleven seconds and one dead lamp are more than he ever meant anyone to have.

L8 · E1_BOATS — "THE QUIET BOATS" (MONEY TRAIL) · DAY 3

Money Trail earned: no manifests = money outside the system. Progress toasts: "Pattern: low out, high back" · "Three weeks ago: the fish-hook". Ally's single *angry*.

	SPEAKER	EMOTION	LINE
1	Ally	neutral	Back to the archive with worse eyes. Every boat mention, three years, laid end to end. Low in the water going out. Riding high coming back. And the port register shows no manifest, ever, for a night crossing on that reach. Cargo that officially doesn't exist is money that officially doesn't move.
2	Ally	neutral	Insomnia made Dot a scientist. Same window, same hours, decades of nights. She wasn't spying. She just knew what belonged on her river — and said hello to what didn't.
3	Ally	surprised	Three weeks ago: the pretty one, close in. Two-note horn. A fish-hook mark on the funnel. I played it on the show with her blessing and thought it was charming.
4	Ally	angry	<i>[cold precision, not volume]</i> Ten days later a fake inspector mapped her window. If he found her through the show — then I handed him the window. Episode forty-one, closing minute, my voice, her view. And if he's a listener, he's heard everything I've said since.

L9 · E1_DELCRUZ — "OFF THE RECORD" (INTERVIEW — THE BRANCH) · DAY 4, THURSDAY

Choice reframed: he already knows she heard him — the choice is the CLEAN COPY. Both results land Day 4 (public by mid-afternoon; protected by evening).

	SPEAKER	EMOTION	LINE
1	Ally	neutral	Sergeant Del Cruz, Harbor Ward, her lunch break, her bench — back to the water. I laid it out: the forty seconds, the inspector, the van, the coin now in her evidence intake.
2	Del Cruz	neutral	I can open the missing-person file — empty house, packed bag, that footage. That's real. What I can't do is turn your theory about boats into warrants. Not on a podcast's say-so.
3	Ally	worried	Then the question that cuts this episode in half. He already knows I heard him — I told the whole city I have his footsteps. What he doesn't know is how cleanly. The full track holds his engine, his gait, the room itself. Publish it, and ten thousand ears go to work. So does he.
4	Del Cruz	neutral	Your show, your call. Just don't pretend silence is neutral either. <i>CHOICE ① Release the full recording — let the city work it ② Publish a transcript only — Del keeps the clean copy</i>
5a	Ally	neutral	<i>(sets aq.e1.truth_public)</i> We released it at noon. By mid-afternoon, a retired Harbourline fleet mechanic had named the engine — the governor retrofit their vans carried after the '09 recall. Hours, not days. The cost came with it: two hundred false sightings, and the van off the streets by dusk.
5b	Ally	neutral	<i>(sets aq.e1.truth_protected)</i> We published the transcript and held the audio. By evening Del had walked the clean copy through properly: the van's plate traces to a shell contractor, but its VIN was last registered to Harbourline. Slower than a crowd. Cleaner than one. And he still doesn't know what we hold.
6	Ally	neutral	<i>(converge)</i> Either way, one thing rides with me now: how you tell the truth is also who you are. Dot's still out there — and her car never left the drive. So how does a frightened woman with a church case leave town?

L10 · E1_TRAIL — "WHERE DOT WENT" (DATA) · DAY 4, EVENING

Coat contradiction fixed (timetable inside the newsletter). Vera contradiction fixed. Final location step added: the bus depot → Chapel Lane.

	SPEAKER	EMOTION	LINE
1	Ally	neutral	The cottage told us she left. Now, where. A pharmacy bag folded flat in the kitchen drawer — St. Brigid's Pharmacy, Larkhill. A town I had to look up.
2	Ally	neutral	Tucked inside the parish newsletter on her mantel, a Christmas card in someone else's hand. "The hills are quiet. You'd hate it. — V." The first evidence that Vera was more than a name Dot mentioned when she was feeling guilty.
3	Ally	neutral	And folded into the same newsletter, a bus timetable: one morning service from Rivermouth passes through Larkhill. Pharmacy, card, route. Not proof. Enough to ring the depot.
4	Ally	neutral	The morning driver remembered her — the only passenger to ask for Chapel Lane before sunrise, church case on her lap. Chapel Lane, Larkhill. I'm driving up at first light. If I'm wrong, it's a long quiet road to be wrong on.

L11 · E1_HILLS — "THE HILL COTTAGE" (LOCATION — CLIMAX) · DAY 5, FRIDAY

Dot explains her escape (closes the phone/police/tip-line logic). Del's unit makes safety real-but-provisional. Progress toasts: "The fog thickens past the church" · "A diesel, somewhere ahead". Dot's *angry* — the script's second and last.

	SPEAKER	EMOTION	LINE
1	Ally	worried	Fog all the way up — the kind that swallows headlights whole. I found the church, then Chapel Lane. And before I saw anything at all, I heard it: a diesel, idling, somewhere behind the white.
2	Ally	worried	Through the fog, for two seconds, it moved: a pale van pulling away without lights. One rear lamp dead. The same dead lamp as eleven seconds of doorbell footage. I stood in the road and let it go — a gate was in reach and a van wasn't.
3	Ally	worried	The cottage door opened before I reached the step — a shape behind the lace curtain, small and absolutely unbothered.
4	Dot	neutral	You always did make a production of things. I heard the gate. Vera heard the gate. The church heard the gate. Come in, love — you're letting the hill in.
5	Dot	angry	And before you say sorry, say it properly: you turned my window into a broadcast, Ally Quinn. My river. My own silly voice. — And I still called your line that night. You know why? I knew you'd hear it. Eventually.
6	Dot	neutral	I went out through the allotments and caught the first bus. Phone switched off since — your gas man handled it at noon, and I wasn't leading him to Vera. Your number was the one I could dial in the dark. I needed the sound somewhere he couldn't take it.
7	Ally	sad	I said I was sorry. Properly. No microphone, no defence, while Vera pretended the kettle needed watching. Then I told them about the van.
8	Ally	neutral	Del had a unit on Chapel Lane before that kettle boiled, and Dot and Vera spent the night somewhere the van doesn't know. She's safe tonight. "Tonight" is doing a lot of work in that sentence.

L12 · E1_CLOSE — "GOODNIGHT, HARBOUR" (PODCAST, VO — MILESTONE) · DAY 6, SATURDAY

Branch-dependent n2: protected truth withholds Harbourline's name on the feed. Practice change made concrete. Coin never airs. Ceremonial requirement. Fires e1.ep01.complete.

	SPEAKER	EMOTION	LINE
1	Ally	neutral	[host register, warmer than the episode's opening] This is Echoes of Havenbay. Dot Ellis is safe. She was found through the life she left in plain sight — a school, a parish, a bus route, and three years of messages nobody had thought to treat as evidence. She declined an interview. Her words: "I'm not content, love. I'm a person."
2a	Ally	worried	(requires aq.e1.truth_public) On the record: the van traces to Harbourline Security — dissolved in 2011, still driving. You heard the full track when we did, and it worked, and it cost: two hundred ghosts in the queue, and the van gone before police reached it. Loud truth. I'd choose it again. I think.
2b	Ally	worried	(requires aq.e1.truth_protected) On the record: the van traces to a dissolved port-security company. Del has asked me to keep its name off this feed — and this time, I'm listening. Quiet truth cost a day of silence I don't want to spend again. I'd choose it again. I think.
3	Ally	neutral	And one thing changes at this show, starting tonight: a voice can tell us where to look without me telling everyone else where it lives. That's the new rule. Dot wrote it; I'm just reading it out.
4	Ally	worried	[measured; to one listener] And now — not as a reporter, but to the man with the careful walk: this show is built on listening. This case taught me who else does. She's safe. The recording is safe. You're the only one still hiding.
5	Dot (voicemail)	happy	[warm; the ritual, reclaimed] It's Dot. From the hills now — imagine that. Vera says hello, which for Vera is a parade. You found an old woman who didn't want a fuss and you made one anyway. Good girl. Say goodnight to the harbour for me, Ally.
6	Ally	neutral	[six words, then the promise] Goodnight, Dot. Goodnight, harbour. — The tip line stays open.
7	—	—	[Somewhere: this episode, playing. A click. Silence. A diesel engine starts.]

V1.2 FIX-BEFORE-RECORDING CHECKLIST (ALL 12)

ITEM	RESOLUTION
1 · Timeline consistency	Absolute clock: 3:04 a.m. Friday; opens Monday; "three nights ago" said once (L1n4); weekday/timestamp thereafter; "last Thursday" removed; both branch results land Day 4.
2 · Coat/timetable contradiction	Timetable folded inside the parish newsletter (L10n3).
3 · Locating the cottage	Bus depot call: the morning driver — "the only passenger to ask for Chapel Lane before sunrise" (L10n4).

4 · "First family evidence" contradiction	"The first evidence that Vera was more than a name Dot mentioned when she was feeling guilty" (L10n2).
5 · Dot explains her escape	L11n6: allotments, first bus, phone off (the gas man handled it), the tip line as the number she could dial in the dark.
6 · Dot demonstrably protected	L11n8: Del's unit on Chapel Lane before the kettle boiled; the night spent somewhere the van doesn't know.
7 · Dead lamp planted	L7n2: pale van at the kerb, left rear lamp dead — paid off L11n2 and grounding the VIN trace.
8 · Street off the public alert	L5n1 "from Rivermouth"; L5n3 says the omission out loud — the show practices the episode's lesson.
9 · Branch reframed around the clean copy	L9n3 "He already knows I heard him... what he doesn't know is how cleanly"; choice = full recording vs transcript only.
10 · "Off the record" corrected	L12n4: "not as a reporter, but to the man with the careful walk."
11 · Protected truth withholds Harbourline	L12n2b: the name stays off the feed; PUBLIC/PROTECTED differ materially through the finale.
12 · Permanent practice change	L12n3: the new rule — "Dot wrote it; I'm just reading it out." Series canon: source-location review before publication.

Also applied: glass removed (photograph + back out, L6n5); Money Trail earned via missing manifests (L8n1); mechanic recognises the fleet-specific governor retrofit (L9n5a); "lanyard doing the work" (L7n1); squeak line clarified (L2n2); progress-toast flavor strings specced for L6/L8/L11; rig-merge deterministic. Deferred to v1.x with the feature backlog: audio scrub/waveform UI, document/archive item family.

PRODUCTION NOTES (DELTA FROM V1.1)

- **Progress toasts:** L6, L8, L11 each define two short flavor strings fired on requirement satisfaction (uses existing ToastService; strings in this doc's leadmeta rows).
- **FTUE rig merge:** pre-placed pieces, zero randomness, cannot fail; nodes 4–5 fire on completion.
- **New canon on approval adds:** Chapel Lane, Larkhill; the '09 Harbourline recall retrofit; the show's source-location rule ("Dot's rule"). All prior canon items stand.
- **Next step after Stephen's read:** table read + runtime timing test → VO LOCK → asset production, portrait generation (Dot, Del), VO recording (Ally, Dot).